

INTERNATIONAL LEADERSHIP AND ORGANIZATIONAL BEHAVIOR

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[STUDY MATERIALS – Week2](#)



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Week 2

NAVIGATING CULTURE

1. A CLOSER LOOK AT CULTURES
2. FOCUS ON RESEARCH: Implicit Theories of Culture in Our Heads
3. CASE DISCUSSION: Decoding Cultures
4. FOCUS ON PRACTICE: Cultural Intelligence
5. WRAP UP

PART 1

A CLOSER LOOK AT CULTURES

Culture...

- Is a complex concept that has many different definitions.
- Can be described as the habitual ways of thinking, acting, and interacting (i.e. “the way we do things around here”).
- Has aptly been called “the software of the mind.” – Geert Hofstede
 - ✓ It is a learned set of “scripts” of procedures (like installing software on a computer) that allows us to tackle everyday tasks, and effectively understand and operate in our social environment.
 - ✓ It is not part of our “hardware” (i.e. our biological makeup per se).
 - ✓ Like software, culture can be updated (i.e. the “software of the mind” can change over time).



Three Important Characteristics of Culture

- Culture is **shared**:
 - Culture comprises the ways of thinking, acting, and interacting that are *the same or similar for all members of a social group* (e.g. religious beliefs, language, cooking, etc.).
 - There is no such thing as a “personal culture” that only one individual has and practices.
- Culture is **learned**:
 - You are not born with it, rather you learn it through observation and socialization over time.
- Culture is **enduring**:
 - Cultures take time to form. They usually do not change very rapidly; however, in times of social tensions and unrest, cultural shifts can be sudden and drastic.



Different Views of Culture



Internalized Societal Norms and Values

- ✓ According to this view culture is so deeply embedded in our minds, that we are hardly aware of it. It appears simply as the natural way of being, thinking, and behaving.
- ✓ Due to this internalization, people are “mental prisoners” to their own culture and have difficulty imagining any other way of being, thinking, and/or behaving.



Readily Available Box of Tools

- ✓ According to this view, people are aware of the cultural “tools” and “scripts” that they are equipped with.
- ✓ Given this awareness, people are free to choose how to use those tools and scripts, and even creatively recombine them (i.e. they have agency in how they use culture).

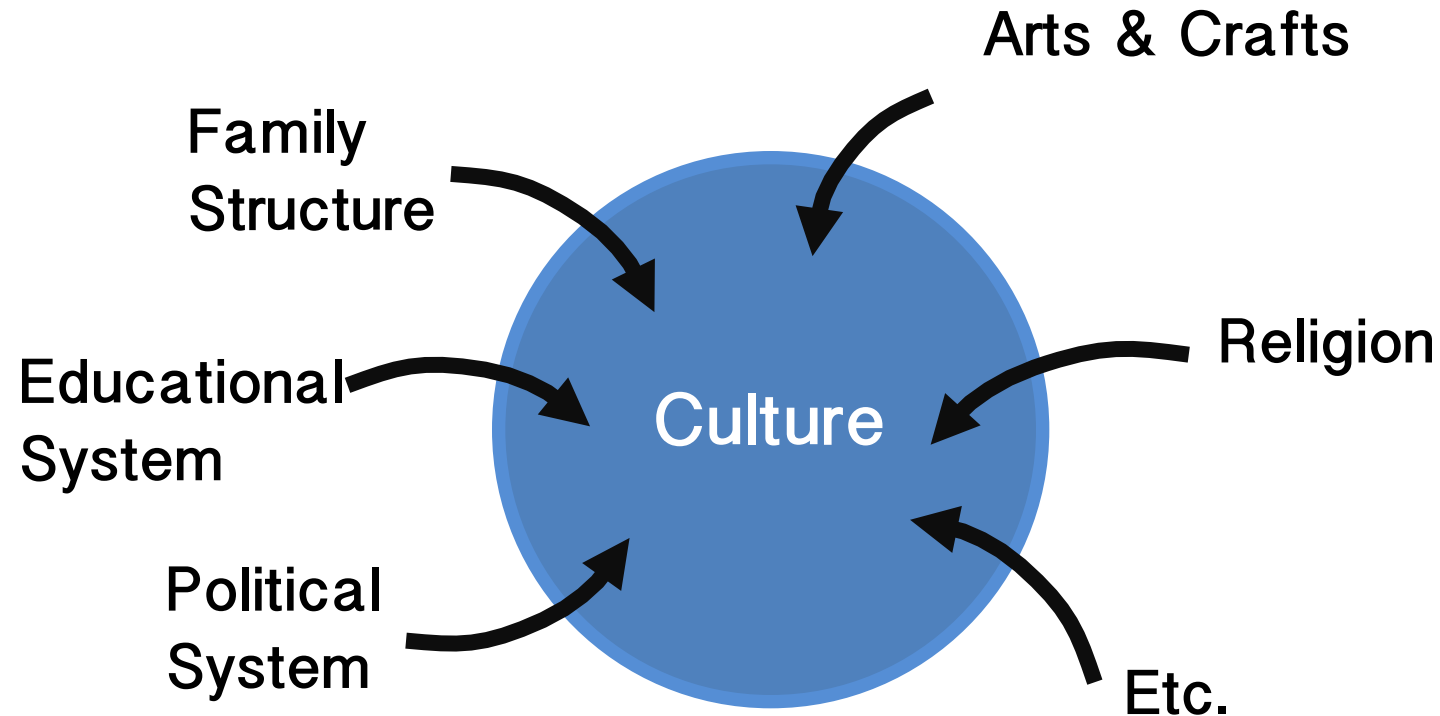
One Culture?

- Culture is not monolithic: in any social group there often are multiple different cultures at different levels and for different social spheres. For example:
 - *National culture*
 - *Regional culture*
 - *Professional culture*
 - *Organizational culture*
 - *Etc.*
- These cultures can overlap. People can simultaneously be members of different cultures and thus are influenced by multiple cultural scripts.



Where Does Culture Come From?

Culture emerges from and is shaped by many different influences.

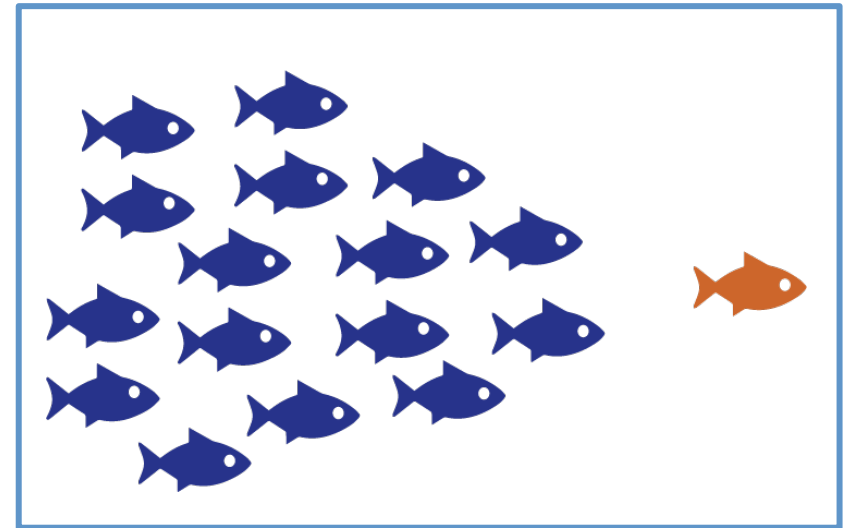


The Power of Culture: How Does It Influence Us?

- **Culture shapes Cognition.**

- It influences how people interpret behaviors, information, visual cues, etc.

E.g. individuals with a Chinese cultural mindset vs. an US American cultural mindset will interpret differently the image of the single fish swimming in front of the group of fish. The US American cultural mindset is that the fish is leading the rest, while the Chinese cultural mindset is that the fish is being chased by the rest.



Morris & Peng's article on culturally based attributions, in the Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 1994, Vol. 67, No. 6, 949-971

<http://www.personal.psu.edu/faculty/n/x/nxy906/COMPS/CLT/cultureandCLT/MorrisPengculturalconstrual.pdf>



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The Power of Culture: How Does it Influence Us?

- Culture shapes emotions.
 - Through observation and socialization people learn to recognize and interpret their own and others' emotions. They learn when particular emotions are considered appropriate.
- *These cultural norms for emotions influence how people interact and create relationships.*



Matsumoto, David, and Hyi Sung Hwang (2012): "Culture and emotion: The integration of biological and cultural contributions." Journal of Cross-Cultural Psychology, vol. 43 no. 1 91-118



Two Approaches to Understanding Cultures

Dissecting Cultures

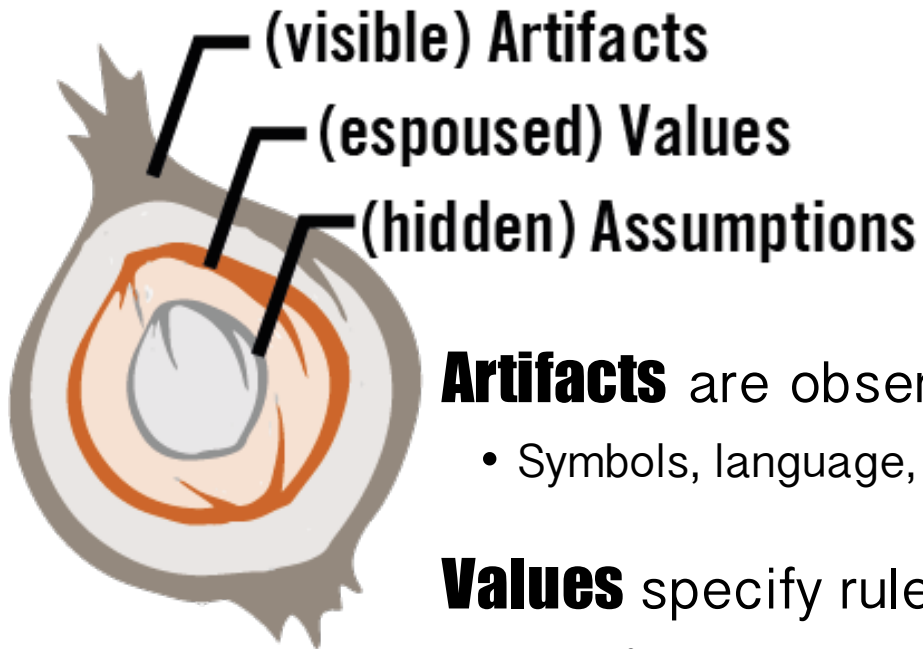
- **Method:** Identifying components and elements of a culture that allow us to better and more fully understand the culture
- **Goal:** Avoiding superficial perception and description of culture

Categorizing/Classifying Cultures

- **Method:** Finding key differences between cultures
- **Goal:** Making cultures concrete, quantifiable, and comparable



“Dissecting” Culture: The Onion Model



Artifacts are observable expressions of culture:

- Symbols, language, physical environment, stories, rituals, etc.

Values specify rules of behavior:

- Beliefs about right vs. wrong, what's important, how to solve problems

Assumptions are the logic underneath culture:

- Taken-for-granted images and moral sentiments, implicit, hard to articulate

Categorizing Culture: Hall's High / Low Context Model

- **Edward Hall** was one of the first researchers to classify cultures with the help of dichotomous dimensions, many of them related to communication behaviors.
- One of the dimensions refers to the amount of contextual information people use to give meaning to and draw meaning from social interactions.
 - ✓ In **high context cultures** (e.g. Saudi Arabia, Japan, Italy, England) much of the information that is critical to understanding the meaning of communication and interaction among people is believed to be contained in the context in which communication occurs (e.g. situation or relationships).
 - ✓ In **low context cultures** (e.g. Germany, Switzerland, Scandinavia, the USA) the meaning of communication and interaction among people is explicitly articulated.



Categorizing Cultures: Hofstede's Dimensions

- **Geert Hofstede** developed one of the most widely used frameworks to understand cultural differences (based on surveys of IBM employees and managers from other companies during the 1960s and 1970s, all in all there were more than 100k participants from 50 countries)
- The framework originally contained **4 dimensions**:
 - ✓ High vs. Low Uncertainty Avoidance
 - ✓ High vs. Low Power Distance
 - ✓ Individualism vs. Collectivism
 - ✓ Masculinity vs. Femininity
- Two additional dimensions were later added to establish the **“6D” Framework**:
 - ✓ Long-term vs. Short-term Orientation
 - ✓ Indulgence vs. Restraint



Categorizing Cultures



A description of the high/ low context dimension and Hall's other dimensions can be found here:

http://changingminds.org/explanations/culture/hall_culture.htm

The Hofstede Center's website has a plethora of info and detailed country profiles:

<http://geert-hofstede.com/cultural-tools.html>



Categorizing Culture: Some Other Models

- **Fons Trompenaar's 7 Cultural Dimensions:**

- ✓ Universalism vs. Particularism, Analyzing vs. Integrating, Individualism vs. Communitarianism, Inner-directed vs. Outer-directed, Time as sequence vs. Time as synchronization, Achieved status vs. Ascribed status, and Equality vs. Hierarchy

- **World Values Survey (WVS)**

- ✓ Found that cultural differences can often be traced to two broad dimensions: a first dimension of “traditional vs. secular-rational values” and a second dimension of “survival vs. self-expression values.”



Categorizing Culture: Some Other Models

– Schwartz Value Survey:

- ✓ Identifies 10 individual level values and 7 cultural orientations; notable for its findings that the 10 individual values are prevalent across national cultures.

– GLOBE Project:

- ✓ Builds on and incorporates some of Hofstede's dimensions, but also explicitly looks at leadership issues across cultures.

– Human Dynamics (HD) Model:

- ✓ Not a national cultural framework, HD has identified three fundamental individual orientations – mental, emotional, and physical– but the framework has also been used to diagnose group, departmental, and even national cultures by articulating which of the three orientations they tend to focus on.



Categorizing Culture



Short summary of the 7 dimensions can be found here:

http://changingminds.org/explanations/culture/trompenaars_culture.htm

Trompenaar's company website has further resources:

<http://www2.thtconsulting.com>

Summary of findings of the WVS can be found here:

<http://www.worldvaluessurvey.org> (check the “Findings & Insights” section)



Categorizing Culture



Method and framework of the Schwartz's survey are described here:

http://www.imo-international.de/index_englisch.htm?/englisch/html/svs_info_en.htm

The Center for Creative Leadership has a good summary of GLOBE:

<http://www.ccl.org/leadership/pdf/assessments/GlobeStudy.pdf>

The Human Dynamics consulting firm's website provides a short summary and points to further resources:

<http://www.humandynamics.com/who-we-are/>



PART 2

FOCUS ON RESEARCH: Implicit Theories of Culture in Our Heads

Limitations of “Cultural Dimensions” Models

- May lead people to develop “sophisticated stereotypes” of a culture rather than motivate them to develop a deeper understanding of that culture.
- Often fail to recognize contradictions or ambiguities in a given culture
 - ✓ e.g. Italian culture has some strong individualist (individual expression, appearance, etc.) and some strong collectivist tendencies (value of the family, local community etc.).
- Downplay the fact that cultures change over time.



Fang T., “Yin Yang: A New Perspective on Culture”, Management and Organizational Review

[http://www.indigenousspsych.org/Interest%20Group/Fang/Fang%20\(2012\),%20Yin%20Yang,%20a%20new%20perspective%20on%20culture%20\(online%20version\).pdf](http://www.indigenousspsych.org/Interest%20Group/Fang/Fang%20(2012),%20Yin%20Yang,%20a%20new%20perspective%20on%20culture%20(online%20version).pdf)



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Understanding the Differences between “Emic” and “Etic” Research Approaches

Etic (outsider perspective)

- ✓ Outsider, deductive, or top-down approach
- ✓ Describes cultures, behaviors, and beliefs from the perspective of the researcher
- ✓ Emphasizes issues that the researcher considers important
- ✓ Strives for objective, universal knowledge

Emic (insider perspective)

- ✓ Insider, inductive, or bottom-up approach
- ✓ Describes cultures, behaviors, and beliefs from the perspective of the members of a culture
- ✓ Emphasizes issues that the members of the culture consider important
- ✓ Strives for accurate representation of subjective knowledge



PART 3

CASE DISCUSSION: Decoding Culture

Case Scenario



Imagine you are promoted to become the leader for a team of process engineers for a Renault / Nissan plant in Brazil.

You have been told that on the day of your arrival your team members expect a short speech from you, in which you will introduce yourself and your goals for the team.

HOW WOULD YOU PREPARE FOR THAT SPEECH?



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Suggested Approach to Tackling the Speech

(1 of 2)

1. Consider the local national culture in Brazil (e.g. using Hofstede's dimensions):
 - ✓ **High power distance:** hierarchy should be respected and inequalities amongst people are acceptable, need to show respect to the elderly and the boss who takes complete responsibility.
 - ✓ **Relatively high collectivism:** people are integrated into strong, cohesive groups. Older and powerful members of community or social group are expected to help a younger younger and less powerful members
 - ✓ Etc.
2. Consider the local management composition (e.g. expat managers that have infused some “foreign” cultural elements in the local culture).
3. Consider the global organizational culture (which values and practices that Renault/Nissan cultivate across all of their sites and facilities worldwide?)



Suggested Approach to Tackling the Speech

(2 of 2)

4. Consider **WHAT** you want to present about yourself (your own values and practices)
 - ✓ You may want to aim for creating a perception of yourself as a leader that balances authenticity and willingness to adapt
5. Consider **HOW** you want to present yourself (communication style, rational/emotional, restrained/expressive, etc.)



PART 4

FOCUS ON PRACTICE:

Cultural

Intelligence

Multiple Intelligences



- ✓ Howard Gardner proposed that people do not possess one intelligence but multiple intelligences.
- ✓ Gardner identified **8 specific intelligences** and argued that individuals differ in how much of each of these intelligences they possess.
- ✓ The intra-personal and inter-personal intelligences have been a foundation for **Daniel Goleman's** popular concept of **Emotional Intelligence (EQ)**.

Emotional Intelligence is NOT Enough

- Emotional Intelligence (EQ), an individual's ability to understand and manage his or her own and others' emotions, is itself culturally embedded:
 - ✓ Our interpretations of emotions / of visible emotional cues differ across cultures.
 - ✓ In order to effectively influence and manage other people's emotions in another culture, you need to be familiar with that culture's emotional norms and scripts.
- That's why international managers need cultural intelligence (CQ).



Cultural Intelligence Framework



There are 3 dimensions:

- The **'mind'** (cognitive): specific knowledge about a culture, and meta-knowledge about cultural dynamics and how to learn quickly about a foreign culture.
- The **'heart'** (motivation/attitude): self-efficacy and persistence in adapting to new culture.
- The **'body'** (skills): adaptive verbal and non-verbal behaviors and competences (e.g. communication skills, conflict management, etc.).

Cultural Intelligence



Earley & Mosakowski (2004)

"Research Edge: Toward Culture Intelligence: Turning Cultural Differences into a Workplace Advantage", Academy of Management Executive (1993-2005), Vol. 18, No. 3 (Aug., 2004), pp. 151-157



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PART 5

WRAP UP

Key Takeaways

- **Frameworks** for understanding culture all provide only partial views of a culture, international leaders need to be aware of the biases and limits of those models.
- All of the frameworks serve as reminders that **empathy – seeing things from the perspective of others** – is critical for international leaders (to understand followers needs and their concerns).
- Understanding the perspective of members of other cultures is an important, but only intermediary step towards a **transcultural orientation**:
 - ✓ Transculturalism embraces cultural diversity but simultaneously strives to transcend cultural divides and barriers and encourages mutual cultural adaptation.

